

The syntax and pragmatics of clause-internal wh-phrases in Valdôtain Patois

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Abstract

In Valdôtain Patois, an understudied Francoprovençal language spoken in Aosta Valley (Italy), wh-phrases can either be fronted or occur clause-internally. In this paper, I analyze the syntax and pragmatics of clause internal wh-phrases, showing that they require to be either activated in the preceding linguistic context or inferable. Based on evidence from word order and parasitic gaps, I argue that in Valdôtain Patois clause-internal wh-phrases are not in-situ, but move to an A'-position at the edge of vP.

Keywords: Valdôtain Patois, clause internal wh-phrases, A'-movement, Low Left Periphery, activation, pragmatics of wh-questions

1 Introduction

Languages vary in the ways they form wh-questions. Some languages, like French, display optionality in wh-fronting. On top of wh-fronting (1a), wh-phrases can also surface in situ, as in (1b). The latter are claimed to be pragmatically marked for presupposition (Chang 1997, Mathieu 2004). Brazilian Portuguese also has two word orders for wh-questions and the order with the wh-phrase clause internally, (2b), is pragmatically marked (Kato 2003, 2013).

- (1) a. **Où** va-s-tu?
where goPRS.2SG-2NOM.SG
'Where are you going?'
b. Tu vas **où**?

French

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- (2) a. **Onde** você foi? **Brazilian Portuguese**
 where you go.PST.PFV.3SG
 ‘Where did you go?’
 b. Você foi (pra) **onde**?
 you go.PST.PFV.3SG (to) where
 ‘Where did you go?’

Rosemeyer (2019: p. 165)

In this paper, I will present data from an understudied Romance language, Valdôtain Patois, in which wh-fronting appears to be optional (3).

- (3) a. **Yeui** te va en vacanse cit an?
 where NOM.2SG go.PRS.2SG on holiday DEM.M.SG year
 ‘Where are you going on holiday this year?’
 b. Te va **yeui** en vacanse cit an?

I will show that optionality is only apparent, as clause internal wh-phrases (CIwh-phrases) are pragmatically marked and require the content of the question to be activated in the previous discourse or inferable. Furthermore, I will show that unlike CIwh-phrases in French, Valdôtain Patois CIwh-phrases are not in situ: they move to an A'-position at the edge of vP. This provides evidence that languages differ in which copy of the chain they prefer in pragmatically marked contexts: French chooses the copy in situ, whereas Valdôtain Patois the one at the edge of vP. The paper is structured as follows. Section 2 introduces Valdôtain Patois and the main data points. Section 3 analyzes their pragmatic contexts. Section 4 introduces diagnostics for movement and Section 5 discusses the data.

2 Clause internal wh-phrases in Valdôtain Patois

Valdôtain Patois (Glottolog code vall1249),¹ henceforth ValPa, is a language from the Francoprovençal group (Figure 1),² spoken by 61.000 speakers (Cavalli & Colletta 2003) in the northwest Italian region Aosta Valley (Brocherel 1958). For the present research, I will make reference to the variety spoken in Morgex, a town in

¹In the scarce literature on the language, the name Valdôtain is often used, e.g. Zanuttini (1997). I refer to it as Valdôtain Patois, because *patuoé* or *patois* is the name native speakers use to refer to their language. The use of this name is therefore a tribute to the inhabitants of Aosta Valley and their heritage.

²This map does not include the Francoprovençal communities of Faeto and Celle di San Vito, in Apulia (Italy) (Nagy 1993, 1996).

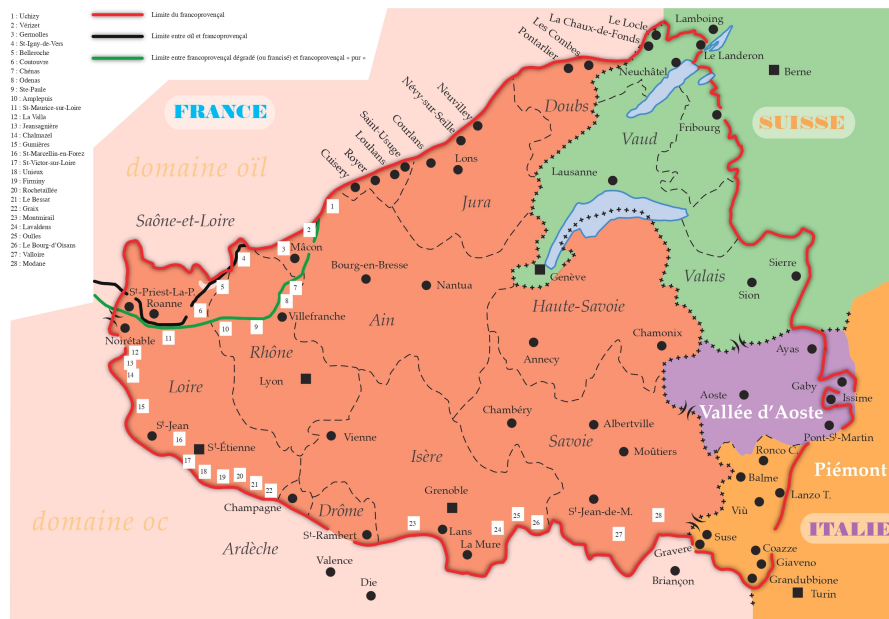


Figure 1: The geographical distribution of the Francoprovençal languages across France, Switzerland, and Italy. Source: Centre d'Études Francoprovençales René Willien, after Tuaillon (1992: p. 337).

the northwest part of the region. ValPa is an SVO language, there are no double object constructions and DO-IO is the default argument order (4).

- (4) Dz' ì baill-à la machina à Tcheunne.
 NOM.ISG have.PRS.ISG give-PST.PTCP DET.F.SG car to Tcheunne
 'I gave the car to Tcheunne.'

In ValPa, there are two question formation strategies: the wh-phrase can be fronted (5a) or surface clause internally (5b). While (5b) could at first sight appear to be an echo question, it differs in both word-order and intonation from the echo question shown in (5c), in which the wh-phrase is accented.

- (5) a. **Dequé** t' atsit-e ì martsà ? **Fronted**
 What NOM.2SG buy.PRS-2SG at.DET market
 'What will you buy at the market ?'
 b. T'atsite **dequé** ì martsà? **Clause internal**
 c. T'atsite ì martsà **DEQUÉ??** **Echo**

All wh-phrases can appear clause internally, be they arguments (6-7), adjuncts

(8), bare (6-8), or D-linked wh-phrases (9). The only exception is *perqué* ‘why’ (10), which must be fronted.

(6) Te baill-e à **qui** t-on livro?
 NOM.2SG give.PRS.2SG to who POSS.2SG-M.SG book
 ‘To whom will you give your book?’

(7) Te le bett-e **yeui** le bott-e?
 NOM.2.SG CL.ACC.PL put-PRS.2SG where DET.DEF.F.PL shoe-PL
 ‘The shoes, where are you putting them?’

(8) Te par **quan** en vacanse?
 NOM.2SG leave.PRS.2SG when on holiday
 ‘When will you leave for holidays?’

(9) a. Te port-e **quin** **livro** en vacanse?
 NOM.2SG bring.PRS.2SG which.M.SG book in holiday
 ‘Which book will you bring on holidays?’

b. Ier t’à predgà **avouë quinte**
 yesterday NOM.2SG-have.PRS.2SG speak-PST.PTCP with which
fenn-e?
 woman-PL
 ‘With which women did you speak yesterday?’

(10) a. **Perqué** te va ì martsà?
 why NOM.2SG go.PRS.2SG to.DET market
 ‘Why do you go to the market?’

b. Te va ***perqué** ì martsà?

Furthermore, CIwh-phrases are also possible in embedded clauses, both finite (11a) and non-finite (12a). In both cases, wh-phrases have matrix scope, just like their fronted counterparts (11b-12b).

(11) a. L’ on pens-ò [que n’
 NOM.3PL have.PRS-3PL think-PST.PTCP COMP NOM.IPL
 ari-en atsit-ò **dequé** pe Tsalende]?
 have.COND.PRS-3PL buy-PST.PTCP what for Christmas
 ‘What did they think we would buy for Christmas?’

b. **Dequé** l’on pensò que n’arien atsitò pe Tsalende?

- b. **Yeui** te pensae d'allé en vacanse cit an?

3 The pragmatics of Valdôtain Patois CIwh-phrases

(13) a. (*E) te la ghe magnà **dove?** **Paduan**
and you it have eaten where
'Where did you eat it?'

b. E te la ghe magnà **dove?** s
and you it have eaten where
'Where did you eat it?'

(Munaro & Poletto 2023: p. 5)

(I4) a. **Dequé** t' atsit-e ì martsà ?
 What NOM.2SG buy.PRS-2SG at.DET market
 'What will you buy at the market ?' **Fronted**

b. T'atsite **dequé** ì martsà?

Clause internal

- (15) a. **Dequé** t' atsit-e ì martsà où t'
 What NOM.2SG buy.PRS-2SG at.DET market or NOM.2SG
 atsit-e ren?
 buy.PRS-2SG nothing
 'What will you buy at the market or is it the case that you won't buy
 anything?'
 b. #T'atsite **dequé** ì martsà où t'atsite ren?

Furthermore, a question with a fronted wh-phrase like (16a) can receive a negative answer, like (16b), whereas its counterpart with the wh-phrase clause internally cannot (17), just like in French (Boeckx 1999, Boucher 2010, a.o.).

- (16) A: **Qui** t' à rencontr-ò ì martsà?
 who NOM.2.SG have.PRS.2.SG meet-PST.PTCP at.DET market
 'Who did you meet at the market?'
 B: Gneun.
 nobody
 'Nobody.'
 (17) A: T' à rencontr-ò **qui** ì martsà?
 NOM.2.SG have.PRS.2.SG meet-PST.PTCP who at.DET market
 'Who did you meet at the market?'
 B: #Gneun.
 nobody
 'Nobody.'

Like in Paduan (Munaro & Poletto 2023), ValPa CIwh-phrases are also felicitous in surprise and disapproval questions (18). Yet, unlike in Paduan, the presence of an *e* 'and' at the beginning of the question is felicitous (18).

- (18) **Context:** Your village is filled with boxes where people can freely exchange books. You usually adopt a book a day, hoping to read them in the future. You thus have overflowing bookshelves. Today you find four awesome books. Once home, your partner sees them and says:
 a. (E) te le bett-e **yoau** tche ci-ce
 and NOM.2SG CL.ACC.PL put-PRS.2SG where all.m.pl DEM.M-PL
 livro?
 book

‘Where will you put all these books?’

On the other hand, in presuppositional questions, the *e* ‘and’ in ValPa is not necessary, and in some cases slightly degraded (19). This is in contrast with Paduan, where the *e* is almost obligatory at the beginning of presuppositional questions (Munaro & Poletto 2023).

(19) **Context:** It’s Thursday, market day in your town. Your partner always visits the market to buy fresh vegetables and fruits, cheese, meat and so on. While you are having breakfast, you ask your partner:

- a. (ʔE) t’ atsit-e **dequé** i martsà voui?
and NOM.2SG buy.PRS-2SG what at.DET market today
‘What will you buy at the market today?’

Note that surprise and disapproval questions tend to be presuppositional questions, as in (18). The presence of *e* in ValPa is only allowed in surprise and disapproval questions. The pattern in ValPa and the differences with that reported for Paduan raise questions about the pragmatics of CIwh-phrases in ValPa, which will be explored more in-depth in the next section.

3.1 *CIwh-phrases need to be activated*

As already discussed, CIwh-phrases are only licensed in pragmatically restricted contexts, which following Chang (1997) and Boucher (2010) a.o. can be tentatively defined as “highly presuppositional”. In this section, I will show that it is not exactly presupposition that licenses CIwh-phrases, but rather the activation status of the propositional content of the question.

Larrivée (2019) argues that wh-in-situ in spoken French can be licensed via ‘discourse activation’ (Dryer 1996) and distinguishes two levels of activation. A question is explicitly activated if the propositional content of the question was mentioned in the discourse, as in (20),³ where the activating chunk of discourse is reported in italics.

³The examples reported by Larrivée (2019) come from the dataset of spoken French ESLO corpus (<http://eslo.huma-num.fr/>), more specifically from the sub-corpus ESLO 2, containing data collected from 2008. The glosses are my own.

- (20) A: Dans les jeu-x antique-s euh *ils* *se*
 in DET.DEF.PL game-PL ancient-PL ehm NOM.3PL.M REFL
dop-ai-ent quand même avec des méthode-s un
 dope-PST-3PL anyway with PART.PL method-PL DET.INDEF
 peu bizarre-s mais [...] *little weird-PL but*
 ‘In the old (olympic) games they’d dope themselves with weird meth-
 ods...’
- B: Ils *se dop-ai-ent* **comment**?
 NOM.3PL.M REFL dope-PST-3PL how
 ‘How did they take drug?’
- A Ils *pren-ai-ent* euh de-s plante-s.
 NOM.3PL take-PST-3PL ehm PART-PL plant-PL
 ‘They took plants.’

Larrivée (2019: p. 120)

On the other hand, a question is non-activated if it introduces a new topic into the discourse, that has not been previously mentioned nor is inferable from the discourse or context, as in (21). As (20-21) show, both contexts license wh-in-situ in colloquial French. Larrivée (2019) argues that in modern day colloquial French wh-in-situ *can* be activated in the preceding linguistic context, but crucially do not need to and are also felicitous in out of the blue questions, like (21).

- (21) Finalement tu *trouv-es* **comment** la *vie* à
 so NOM.2SG find-PRS.2SG how DET.DEF.F.SG life in
 Orléans?
 Orléans?
 ‘So, how you find living in Orléans?’

Larrivée (2019: p. 120)

Garassino (2022) identifies another context in which wh-in-situ is licensed: inferable. A question is inferable when its propositional content is not explicitly mentioned, but is easily retrievable through the speaker’s knowledge of the world (Prince 1981, Gundel, Hedberg & Zacharski 1993), as in (22).⁴ Another common occurrence of wh-in-situ in French is represented by specific and common social constructs, where the speaker anticipates a predictable discourse move (23), a subtype of inferrable contexts.

⁴This example, like many reported in Garassino (2022), comes from the corpus of spoken languages C-ORAL-ROM (Cresti & Moneglia 2005). Glosses are my own.

(22) A: Et qu'est-ce que tu as achet-é d'autre
 and what NOM.2SG have.PRS.2SG buyPST.PTCP other
 alors?
 then

'And so, what else did you buy?'

B: Et ben on a achet-é la table
 and well NOM.3SG have.PRS.3SG buy-PST.PTCP DET.DEF.F.SG table
 avec le-s quatre chaise-s. Sept-cent balles.
 with DET.DEF-PL four chair-PL. seven-hundred balls

'Well, we bought a table with four chairs. 700 euros.'

A: Pour mett-re où?
 for put-INF where
 'To put where?'

Garassino (2022: p. 35)

(23) Ça fait combien s'il vous
 DEM.3SG.N make.PRS.3SG how.much REFL-NOM.3SG.M DAT.2PL
 plaît-t?
 please-PRS.3SG

'How much is this please?' Rossi-Gensane & Ursi (2020: p. 154)

(24) A: Va bene, ved-o che hai
 go.PRS.3SG well, see-PRS.1SG COMP have.PRS.2SG
 risol-to.
 resolve-PST.PTCP

'Ok, it seems you've fixed that.'

B: Risol-to cosa? Vieni fuori.
 resolve-PST.PTCP what? come.IMP.2SG outside

'Fixed what? Come outside.' Garassino (2022: p. 46)

Garassino (2022) argues that Italian is more restrictive than French and only allows wh-in-situ if the propositional content of the question was activated in the preceding linguistic context (24).⁵

In ValPa, CI-wh-phrases are licensed by activation in the preceding linguistic context, as outlined in (25). Note that in (25) the use of *e* 'and' at the beginning of the clause is felicitous (cf. 19-18).

⁵The Italian data analyzed in Garassino (2022) come from the Perugia Corpus (PEC) (Spina 2014). Glosses are my own.

- (25) A: Ivana e Marco m' ont deut que
 Ivana and Marco DAT.ISG havePRS.3PL say.PST.PTCP COMP
part-on en vacanse.
 leave-PRS.3PL on holiday
 'Ivana and Marco told me they will go on holiday.'
 B: E part-on **quan?**
 and leave-PRS.3PL when
 'And when do they leave?'

Furthermore, CIwh-phrases are licensed when the propositional content of the question is inferable from the context, linguistic or extra-linguistic, and the speaker's knowledge of the world, as in (26).

- (26) **Context:** This year, you and all the people living in your area have been harvesting blueberries like crazy. Of the endless supply of blueberries you harvested, you have made jam, pies, put them under spirit, and frozen them for future use. Yet, you have a few extra kilos. You try to gift them, but nobody you know wants them, as everyone is in the same situation as you, so you store them in the cellar, hoping to find a recipient soon. A few days later, you and your partner go to the cellar to get a bottle of wine and you see that the blueberries are not there. Puzzled, you ask your partner:

- a. T' à baill-à à **qui** le loufi-e?
 NOM.2SG have.PRS.2SG give-PST.PTCP to whom DET.PL blueberry
 'To whom did you give the blueberries?'

Finally, CIwh-phrases are felicitous in common social constructs, like at a cash register (27).

- (27) Te de-yo **veu?**
 DAT.2SG owe.PRS-1SG how much
 'How much do I owe you?'

Nevertheless, unlike in French, ValPa CIwh-phrases are infelicitous if the propositional content of the clause is non-activated (Larrivée 2019). In (28), the wh-phrase must be fronted.

- (28) **Context:** It's January and you are in the library studying for the finals with your friend. At one point, you ask him:

- a. **Yeui** v-a Tcheunne en vacanse ci tsatèn?
 Where go-PRS.3SG Tcheunne in holiday DEM.M.SG summer
 ‘Where is Tcheunne going on holiday this summer?’
- b. # Va **yeui** Tcheunne en vacanse ci tsatèn?

The speaker uttering (28) and the interlocutor might very well presuppose that Tcheunne will go on holiday, because e.g. his family goes on holiday twice a year since he was a child. Nonetheless, the question cannot be uttered to introduce a new topic into the discourse, which has not been previously mentioned nor is inferable from the discourse or context. This suggests that presupposition alone is not sufficient to license CIwh-phrases.

To sum up, ValPa CIwh-phrases are only felicitous if the propositional content of the question is either activated or inferable. As shown in Table 1, ValPa can be situated between French and the more restrictive Italian. As Larrivée (2019) argues, the licensing of wh-in-situ in French in non-activated contexts is a relatively recent diachronic development of the language, which until the 1960’s displayed the same pattern as ValPa today.

Table 1: Activation levels necessary for non-fronted wh-phrases in French, Italian, and ValPa

Language	Activated	Inferable	Non-activated
Italian	+	-	-
ValPa	+	+	-
French	+	+	+

In this section I have argued, based on work by Larrivée (2019) and Garassino (2022), that it is the activation status or inferable nature of the question that licenses CIwh-phrases. Presupposition is indeed present in many of the examples reported here, yet it is not what licenses CIwh-phrases. The latter are licensed when the propositional content of the question was activated in the preceding linguistic content or is inferable. ValPa thus compares to colloquial French up until the 1960’s (Larrivée 2019). The next section will discuss the position of these wh-phrases, arguing that, unlike in French, ValPa CIwh-phrases are not in situ.

4 CIwh-phrases: in situ or ex situ?

The previous section has highlighted the great similarity in pragmatic licensing of non-fronted wh-phrases between ValPa and French (up until the 1960's), but did not address the question of the position of said wh-phrases. The consensus on French non-fronted wh-phrases is that they are in situ (Lasnik & Saito 1992, Chang 1997, Larrivé 2019, a.o.). As far as ValPa is concerned, up until this point, I have used the term CIwh-phrases as a generic term to refer to non-fronted wh-phrases. In this section I will argue that ValPa CIwh-phrases are not in situ, but *ex situ*: they move to an A'-position at the edge of vP.

As mentioned in Section 2, the unmarked order of arguments in ValPa is DO-IO (29a). Thus, the IO-DO word order in (29b) suggests that the *wh*-phrase *à qui* is not in base position.

- (29) a. Marco baill-e lo libro à Ivana.
 Marco give.PRS-3SG DET.M.SG book to Ivana
 ‘Marco will give the book to Ivana.’
 b. Marco baill-e [à qui]_k lo libro _k?
 Marco give.PRS-3SG to who DET.M.SG book
 ‘To whom will Marco give the book?’

The same is witnessed with locative PPs. In (30), the default words order is DO-PP (30). Yet, in the wh-question (31), the CIwh-phrase *yeni* ‘where’ must precede the DO (31a), the opposite order being degraded, unless it’s an echo question.

- (30) Marco l' à bett-ò lo libro en
Marco NOM.3.SG have.PRS-3SG put-PST.PTCP DET.M.SG book in
borsa.
bag
'Marco put the book in the bag.'
- (31) a. Marco l' à bett-ò [**yɛui**]_k
Marco NOM.3.SG-have.PRS-3SG put-PST.PTCP where DET.M.SG
lo libro _k?
book
'Where did Marco put the book?'
- b. ??Marco l'à bettò lo libro **yɛui**?

The next piece of evidence against an in situ analysis of ValPa CIwh-phrases comes from parasitic gaps. A parasitic gap is "a gap that is dependent by the existence of another gap" (Engdahl 1983: p. 5). As shown in (32a), as opposed to (32b), parasitic gaps can only be licensed by *overt* A'-movement of the wh-phrase, which becomes the antecedent of the real gap, t_i , and licenses the *pg* in the adjunct clause (Engdahl 1983, Culicover 2001, Nunes 2004, a.o.).

- (32) a. Which book_{*i*} did you review $_i$ [without reading *pg*] ?
 b. *Who reviewed which book [without reading *pg*] ?

The ValPa verbs used in the parasitic gap examples are the ditransitive *baillé* 'to give' and *deuscueté* 'to discuss', whose PPs cannot be dropped (33-34).

- (33) Dz' $_i$ baill-à lo livro *(à
 NOM.ISG have.PRS.ISG give-PST.PTCP DET.DEF.M.SG book to
 Tcheunne).
 Tcheunne
 'I gave the book to Tcheunne.'

- (34) Dz' $_i$ pò deuscuet-ò *(avouë Tcheunne).
 NOM.ISG have.PRS.ISG NEG argue-PST.PTCP with Tcheunne
 'I didn't argue with Tcheunne.'

In the examples (35b), the CIwh-phrases *à qui* licenses the parasitic gap in the adjunct clause *après ai baillà de soou*, precisely as its fronted counterpart (35b). The same pattern is witnessed in (36).

- (35) a. T' à port-ò à **qui**_{*i*} la spèiza $_i$
 2SG have.PRS.2SG bring-PST.PTCP to whom DET.F.SG grocery
 [après ai baill-à *pg* de soou]?
 after have-INF give-PST.PTCP PART money
 'To whom did you bring groceries after having given money?'
 b. **À qui**_{*i*} t'`à portò la spèiza $_i$ [après ai baillà *pg* de soou]?
 (36) a. T' à mand-ò à catqu-é **qui**_{*i*} $_i$ [enco
 2SG have.PRS.2SG send-PST.PTCP to shit-INF who even
 doanque deuscueté *pg*] ?
 before argue-INF
 'Who did you tell to fuck off before even arguing?'
 b. **Qui**_{*i*} t'`à mandò à catqué $_i$ [enco doanque discut-é *pg*] ?

The next question concerns the position of CIwh-phrases. As shown in (37), the CIwh-phrase must follow the low manner adverb *bien* ‘well’, one of the lowest adverbs in the hierarchy proposed by Cinque (1999), located just above vP.

- We can, therefore, argue that ValPa CIwh-phrases are not in situ, but rather land in a position just above vP.

(38)

```
graph TD
    TP --> Ellipsis1[...]
    TP --> TopP1[TopP]
    TopP1 --> Top1[Top]
    TopP1 --> FocP[FocP]
    FocP --> Foc[Foc]
    FocP --> TopP2[TopP]
    TopP2 --> Top2[Top]
    TopP2 --> vP[vP]
    vP --> Ellipsis2[...]
```

(39) a. **Chi** ga-tu catà? Trevisan
 who have=cl_{PS} met

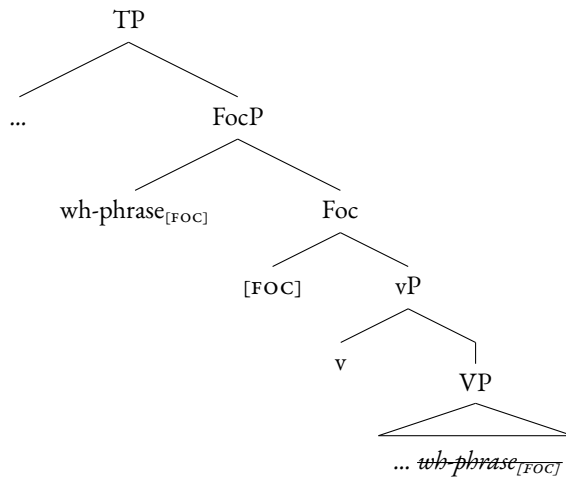
‘Who have you met?’

b. Ga-tu catà **chi**?

(Bonan 2019: p. 15)

Based on evidence from word order and Subject Clitic Inversion, Bonan (2019) argues that wh-phrases like *chi* in (39b) are not in situ. Following Belletti (2004, 2006) and Kato (2013), she proposes that Trevisan wh-phrases move from their base position to FocP in LLP, in what she defines *Wh-to-Foc* movement, as outlined in (40).

(40)



Similarly to Trevisan (Bonan 2019), ValPa CIwh-phrases are not in situ but target an A'-position in the LLP at the edge of vP (41).

(41) [_{TP} [_{MannerAdvP} [_{LLP} wh-phrase [_{vP} ...]]]]

For reasons of space, the present paper does not allow for an in-depth discussion of whether, like in Trevisan, ValPa CIwh-phrases target FocP, thus undergoing focus movement, or rather move to a dedicated wh-position and I refer the reader to Seguin (in press[b]).

5 Discussion

In this paper, I have presented novel data on clause internal wh-phrases (CIwh-phrases) in an understudied Romance language: Valdôtain Patois (ValPa). Besides the typological contribution, these data are interesting for several reasons.

As discussed in Section 3, there is no optionality in wh-fronting in ValPa, as CIwh-phrases are pragmatically marked. At first sight, ValPa CIwh-phrases

appeared to be highly presuppositional, as argued by Chang (1997), Boucher (2010), Kato (2003, 2013), and Munaro & Poletto (2023) a.o. for *wh-in-situ* in French, Brazilian Portuguese, and certain Northern Italian Dialects. However, I have shown that presupposition is only a secondary factor, following from the broad pragmatic status of *CIwh*-phrases. In fact, in order for *CIwh*-phrases to be licensed, the propositional content of the question must be activated or inferable (Larrivée 2019, Garassino 2022). In Section 3, I have compared ValPa to French and Italian and showed that ValPa is less restrictive Italian, in which non *wh*-fronting is only allowed when the propositional content of the question is activated, but more restrictive than modern day French, where *wh-in-situ* is not pragmatically marked anymore. Obenauer (2004, 2006) argues that *wh-in-situ* in French first emerged in special pragmatic contexts and, after undergoing a diachronic change (Larrivée 2019), it is nowadays very frequent in both standard and several colloquial French varieties. Unfortunately, there is no corpus of ValPa, therefore it is hard to make claims about the diachronic change in *wh*-fronting. Nonetheless, based on the current stage and the extensive research on the emergence of *wh-in-situ* in French, it is reasonable to hypothesize that ValPa will evolve along the same path as French and soon allow *CIwh*-phrases to be less pragmatically restricted.

The second observation is that, *CIwh*-phrases in ValPa are not *in situ*: they move to an *A'*-position in the LLP at the edge of *vP*. Recall that the *wh*-phrase in base position is only licit in echo questions, which are also pragmatically marked. This means that, unlike French (Chang 1997, Boucher 2010, Mathieu 1999, a.o.), ValPa has two positions which are associated with specific, yet distinct, pragmatic restrictions: the base position (in echo questions) and the one at the edge of *vP* (in discourse activated or inferable contexts). This evidence suggests that languages differ substantially in which position(s) they mark pragmatically. In French for instance only one position is pragmatically restricted, the base position, whereas in ValPa there are two positions. Finally, there are languages that do not distinguish between positions for pragmatically different contexts, like Romanian, in which even in echo questions *wh*-fronting is required, (42).

- (42) a. *Ion a adus CE? **Romanian**
 Ion has brought what
 'Ion has bought WHAT??'

b. CE Ion a adus?

(Elena Soare, pers. comm.)

The question that this observation raises is what determines the crosslinguistic variation in the choice of which copy (or position) is associated with certain pragmatic restrictions. More specifically, why in ValPa it is the copy in the LLP that displays specific pragmatic restrictions, while in other languages it is the one in situ? One possibility is that these pragmatic restrictions are encoded in the syntax; another possibility is that the grammar allows different structures, to which different meanings are then associated.

Finally, given the present data one is bound to wonder how the different word orders (fronted VS clause internal) in ValPa are derived and how pragmatic constraints play a role in the derivation of wh-questions, in ValPa and cross-linguistically. More specifically, these data raise the question of whether the ‘optionality’ is accounted for in the syntax or post-syntactically, see Seguin (in press[a]) for an analysis of the different word orders and a discussion of the mechanisms responsible for the optionality.

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